

# Response to LLM energy use objections

Posted by u/Ninjinka • 0 points • 10 comments

The idea that “more energy use = moral bad” is backwards. Energy is the fuel for civilization. The question should not be “how do we use less energy?” but “how do we produce more energy, and make it cheap?” If you look at any metric of human progress (lifespan, literacy, computation, information, wealth) it all scales with energy consumption. Every leap forward has been powered by consuming *more* energy, not less.

More demand for energy drives more production of energy. Energy doesn't get cleaner, cheaper or more abundant by wanting it to. It gets that way because there's pressure to produce more.

The energy requirements of AI datacenters are forcing innovation. Suddenly there's an economic reason to build next-gen reactors, more transmission, better storage, and new generation methods.

Just think about GPUs themselves. They didn't get faster because engineers had spare time, they got faster because gamers, miners, and now model trainers demanded insane performance. It will be the same with energy. When a civilization stops demanding energy, it's signaling that it's stopped wanting to build.

## Comments

u/br\_k\_nt\_eth • 1 points • 2025-10-06 20:40 UTC

Respectfully, water is a far bigger concern, and I'm not sure that downplaying the very serious impacts is the way to go here.

u/Ninjinka • 1 points • 2025-10-06 20:56 UTC

There is some merit to the water concerns, but it can easily be overblown.

Right off the bat, it's worth remembering water cannot be destroyed. It's not like oil that gets burned and disappears. It's part of a closed planetary system. Also, water used for datacenter cooling is generally not clean potable water.

That being said, the most legitimate objection is that even though it doesn't destroy water, it relocates water (through the water cycle). And if it's temporarily relocating water away from an

area that is low on water, that's bad.

However, companies are strongly incentivized to build datacenters in regions where water is abundant and there is good infrastructure. They don't want to build where they aren't confident about water availability.

And this is another area where they're innovating and increasing supply in response to demand: <https://www.datacenterdynamics.com/en/news/elon-musk-xai-memphis-supercomputer-wastewater-treatment>

Finally, water-use by datacenters is a tiny fraction of water used by other industries. Agriculture uses 70% of global freshwater withdrawals. Industry uses another 20%. Datacenters use less than 1% globally. Concern is overblown.

**u/br\_k\_nt\_eth** • 2 points • 2025-10-06 23:02 UTC

I'm sorry, but you need to look at what's happening in Hood River and Boardman, Oregon before you get this dismissive about it. The sheer burden of cost on rural rate payers, the damage to the local ecosystems, and the way tech companies have fought to keep the sheer amount of usage secret can't be ignored or glossed over. The fact that you handwave the displacement this way is such a red flag.

I get that this is a fun hobby, but there needs to be some token amount of perspective. This? This is not going to win people over to your cause, which is apparently carrying water for billionaires and mega corps?

**u/Ninjinka** • -1 points • 2025-10-06 23:21 UTC

There's nothing happening in Hood River and Boardman. Those are not water-stressed regions by any stretch of the imagination. The Columbia River Basin is one of the most water-rich systems on the continent. Google's entire 2021 water use at The Dalles (~355 million gallons) equals ~7.9 minutes of the Columbia River's average flow at The Dalles. The "water crisis" framing exists because journalists see "millions of gallons" and forget to compare it to billions.

The "burden on rural ratepayers" is totally backwards. Data centers buy water at industrial rates, often subsidizing municipal infrastructure upgrades. Google's The Dalles agreement literally funded water-system expansion for the whole town ([https://www.thedalles.org/news\\\_detail\\\_T4\\\_R180.php](https://www.thedalles.org/news\_detail\_T4\_R180.php)).

Just because you can find articles titled "Data centers intensify water fears" doesn't mean the fears are well-founded. Look at the data.

**u/br\_k\_nt\_eth** • 3 points • 2025-10-06 23:31 UTC

You are flat out wrong, not just with the idea that there's nothing going on but also that this area isn't water stressed and increasingly so. I live in the region, and you don't even have The Dalles numbers right. You need to do more research before you start licking boots for billionaires this hard. Like, are you intentionally

obfuscating here or something? Were you hoping you weren't talking to a local who'd call you out?

**u/Fluorine3** • 3 points • 2025-10-06 20:33 UTC

I do hope AI will become a major driver for clean, sustainable energy sources, such as more solar and wind energy. Let AI/renewable energy lobbyists battle Oil lobbyists.

**u/True\_Butterscotch940** • 1 points • 2025-10-06 20:17 UTC

Except we're not seeing more production of energy: LLM data centers are consuming a disproportionate amount of electricity, driving everyone's energy bills much higher.

**u/Ninjinka** • -1 points • 2025-10-06 20:23 UTC

This is just...false? It won't happen overnight, but we are definitely seeing more production of energy as a direct result of new datacenters:

[<https://penncapital-star.com/energy-environment/three-mile-island-nuclear-power-plant-will-reopen-in-deal-to-power-microsoft-data-centers>](<https://penncapital-star.com/energy-environment/three-mile-island-nuclear-power-plant-will-reopen-in-deal-to-power-microsoft-data-centers>)

[<https://www.tomshardware.com/tech-industry/artificial-intelligence/elon-musk-xai-power-plant-overseas-to-power-1-million-gpus>](<https://www.tomshardware.com/tech-industry/artificial-intelligence/elon-musk-xai-power-plant-overseas-to-power-1-million-gpus>)

[<https://www.tomshardware.com/tech-industry/artificial-intelligence/openai-follows-elon-musks-lead-gas-turbines-to-be-deployed-at-its-first-stargate-site-for-additional-power>]  
(<https://www.tomshardware.com/tech-industry/artificial-intelligence/openai-follows-elon-musks-lead-gas-turbines-to-be-deployed-at-its-first-stargate-site-for-additional-power>)

**u/AutoModerator** • 0 points • 2025-10-06 20:03 UTC

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**u/AutoModerator** • 1 points • 2025-10-06 20:03 UTC

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